

RATFOLK

A NEW MONSTER FACTION

Ratfolk are not united by ideology, ancestry, or ambition. They are united by necessity.

Where other humanoid factions rely on tradition, honor, or hierarchy, ratfolk rely on proximity and advantage. A ratfolk warren exists because it must, not because its members wish to cooperate. Survival comes first. Everything else is negotiable.

Ratfolk are designed to function as a self-contained monster faction, not a single stat block scaled up and down. They operate across a full range of challenge ratings, from harmless noncombatants to dangerous local tyrants, with clear internal roles and predictable behavior patterns.

Unlike disciplined humanoids, ratfolk do not fight as armies. They excel at ambushes, opportunistic attacks, infiltration, and attrition. They are strongest in tight spaces, cluttered environments, and locations they can abandon and reclaim repeatedly.

SELFISH BY NATURE

Every ratfolk believes the same thing, instinctively and without apology: my survival matters more than yours.

This does not make them stupid or purely cowardly. It makes them practical. Ratfolk cooperate only when cooperation increases their odds of survival. The moment it does not, alliances fracture, leaders are questioned, and retreats begin.

Ratfolk will:

- Flee when wounded
- Abandon allies without hesitation
- Redirect danger toward others
- Return later when conditions improve

This behavior is consistent across all roles and challenge ratings.

FRAGILE AUTHORITY

Ratfolk leadership is immediate, personal, and unstable. Chieftains, enforcers, and plague masters rule through fear, intimidation, and proximity. Their authority rarely extends beyond the space they can physically dominate.

There are no standing armies, no grand strategies, and no lasting chains of command. When a leader falls or is isolated, ratfolk morale collapses rapidly. Survivors scatter, hide, or turn on one another rather than rally.

INDUSTRY WITHOUT SAFETY

Ratfolk are prolific scavengers and builders. Their tools are crude, their machines unreliable, and their solutions temporary. A device that works once is considered

successful. A trap that collapses after triggering is still useful.

This mindset produces:

- Unstable explosives
- Hazardous lairs
- Unpredictable battlefield conditions

Ratfolk accept these risks readily—especially when someone else is closer to the danger.

PLAGUE AS A TOOL

Filth, disease, and contamination are facts of life in ratfolk warrens. Rather than avoid them, ratfolk adapt to them and weaponize them. Plague adepts and plague masters are valued not for faith or wisdom, but for utility.

Even so, reverence has limits. A plague master surrounded by allies is powerful. One left alone is expendable.

HOW RATFOLK FEEL AT THE TABLE

Ratfolk encounters should feel unstable.

They begin aggressively, fracture quickly, and rarely end cleanly. Enemies retreat, reappear, and change tactics. Killing leaders matters. Ignoring wounded ratfolk invites theft, sabotage, and ambushes later.

They are not noble villains. They are not tragic monsters. They are persistent, adaptable survivors—messy, selfish, and difficult to eradicate.



RUNNING RATFOLK

Ratfolk are not meant to be fought like soldiers, beasts, or honorable humanoids. They are a problem that moves, adapts, and refuses to resolve cleanly.

This section explains how Ratfolk behave during encounters and how to use them effectively at the table.

CORE PRINCIPLE: SURVIVAL FIRST

Ratfolk do not fight to win battles. They fight to stay alive and improve their position.

Every tactical decision they make—advancing, retreating, betraying allies, or surrendering—flows from this principle. Ratfolk rarely fight to the death unless cornered or controlled by fear.

If a ratfolk can escape, it will.

OPENING AN ENCOUNTER

Ratfolk prefer to begin encounters on their terms.

Common opening behaviors include:

- Ambushes from concealment
- Attacks against isolated or distracted targets
- Traps, debris, smoke, or hazards to limit movement
- Using noncombatants or clutter as obstacles

Ratfolk rarely announce themselves. If the party is aware of Ratfolk before combat begins, it is usually because the Ratfolk intended to be noticed—or failed.

FIGHTING WHILE WINNING

When Ratfolk believe they have the advantage, they act boldly.

During this phase, Ratfolk will:

- Press attacks against wounded enemies
- Exploit numbers and positioning
- Use unstable devices aggressively
- Allow weaker Ratfolk to absorb danger

This confidence is shallow. It depends entirely on momentum, numbers, and visible leadership.

WHEN THE FIGHT TURNS

The moment the odds shift, Ratfolk behavior changes dramatically.

Triggers include:

- Leaders being killed or isolated
- Ratfolk being reduced below half strength
- Unexpected enemy resilience
- Loss of escape routes

At this point, Ratfolk will:

- Disengage and flee
- Hide or scatter

- Abandon allies
- Redirect danger toward others
- Bargain or surrender if escape fails

This collapse should feel sudden and messy, not gradual or heroic.

LEADERS AND MORALE

Ratfolk leaders do not inspire loyalty—they suppress panic.

While leaders are present:

- Weaker Ratfolk hesitate to flee
- Cooperation is enforced through fear
- Tactics remain loosely coordinated

When leaders fall:

- Morale collapses rapidly
- Ratfolk scatter independently
- Survivors prioritize escape over revenge

Killing or isolating a leader should noticeably shorten encounters.

RETREAT IS NOT DEFEAT

Ratfolk retreat often—and return frequently.

A fleeing Ratfolk group may:

- Regroup elsewhere in the warren
- Circle ahead to set new traps
- Shadow the party
- Return later with reinforcements
- Target supplies, mounts, or allies

Ratfolk are persistent threats, not single encounters.



RATFOLK LADDER

Name	Challenge Rating	Description
Ratfolk Pup	0	Noncombatant young that flees, hides, and alerts others. Used for narrative pressure and lair dynamics rather than combat.
Ratfolk Commoner	0	Civilian laborer and tunnel worker armed with tools or improvised weapons. Breaks morale immediately when threatened.
Ratfolk Fence	0	Black-market broker and information dealer. Avoids combat and relies on hired protection or escape routes.
Ratfolk Scavenger	1/8	Fodder skirmisher armed with scrap weapons and filth tricks. Cowardly but persistent when looting is possible.
Ratfolk Thief	1/4	Urban disruptor that steals items mid-fight and relies on bonus action Hide or Disengage to escape.
Ratfolk Scout	1/4	Lookout and tunnel runner that triggers alarms, marks targets, and retreats to draw enemies into danger.
Ratfolk Warrior	1/2	Defensive frontliner armed with spear and shield. Holds ground only while leaders or enforcers remain nearby.
Ratfolk Spy	1	Infiltrator and intelligence gatherer skilled in disguise, signals, and urban manipulation. Withdraws once exposed.
Ratfolk Skirmisher	1	Mobile fighter that relies on hit-and-run tactics, speed, and terrain abuse rather than sustained combat.
Ratfolk Grenadier	2	Chaos unit that uses unstable bombs, smoke, and acid. Dangerous to everyone, including allies, with frequent mishaps.
Ratfolk Bodyguard	2	Personal protector hired or coerced to defend a specific individual. Intercepts attacks but abandons lost causes quickly.
Ratfolk Assassin	3	Elite ambush killer that relies on poison, surprise damage, and escape rather than prolonged fighting.
Ratfolk Engineer	3	Specialist who deploys traps, devices, and tunnel hazards. Shapes the battlefield while avoiding direct combat.
Ratfolk Plague Adept	3	Filth-wielding specialist that spreads disease clouds and debilitating effects through proximity and attrition.
Ratfolk Enforcer	4	Brutal disciplinarian who maintains order through fear and example. Prevents flight until authority collapses.
Ratfolk Plague Master	5	Power figure that commands advanced contagions and corrupts lairs. Most dangerous when left unchecked.
Ratfolk Chieftain	6	Local tyrant who rules through intimidation and proximity. Gains strength from nearby allies but weak when isolated.



RATFOLK PUP

RATFOLK PUP

Tiny humanoid (ratfolk), unaligned

Armor Class 11

Hit Points 2 (1d4)

Speed 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
6 (–2)	12 (+1)	10 (+0)	6 (–2)	10 (+0)	6 (–2)

Skills Stealth +3

Senses darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 10

Languages Ratfolk

Challenge 0 (0 XP)

Scatter! If another ratfolk within 10 feet of the pup is reduced to 0 hit points, the pup can immediately take the Hide action.

Not Worth the Risk. The ratfolk pup automatically fails saving throws against being frightened, but it automatically succeeds on saving throws made to flee, hide, or escape grapples.

ACTIONS

Desperate Bite. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +3 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 1 piercing damage.

REACTIONS

Panic Reflex. When the ratfolk pup takes damage, it can use its reaction to move up to 15 feet without provoking opportunity attacks.

- Noncombatant young; intended for lairs, nests, and moral stakes rather than combat.
- Panic-driven mobility reinforces swarm-and-scatter ratfolk behavior.
- Extremely fragile; best used in numbers or as environmental detail.



RATFOLK SCAVENGER

RATFOLK SCAVENGER

Small humanoid (ratfolk), unaligned

Armor Class 12 (scrap armor)

Hit Points 9 (2d6 + 2)

Speed 30 ft., climb 20 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
10 (+0)	14 (+2)	12 (+1)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	8 (–1)

Skills Perception +2, Stealth +4

Senses darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 12

Languages Common, Ratfolk

Challenge 1/8 (25 XP)

Filthy Fighter. The first time the scavenger hits a creature on its turn, the target has disadvantage on the next ability check it makes before the end of its next turn.

ACTIONS

Rusty Blade. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 4 (1d4 + 2) slashing damage.

Junk Throw. *Ranged Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, range 20/60 ft., one target. *Hit:* 4 (1d4 + 2) bludgeoning damage.

BONUS ACTIONS

Opportunistic Coward. When the ratfolk scavenger has half its hit points or fewer, it can take the Disengage or Hide action as a bonus action on its turn.

REACTIONS

Mine Now. When a creature within 5 feet of the scavenger drops an item, is disarmed, or falls unconscious, the scavenger can use its reaction to interact with one unattended object in that creature's space.

- Low-level skirmisher that capitalizes on chaos and fallen gear.
- Mobility and reaction economy reward hit-and-run tactics.
- Best used in cluttered terrain, refuse heaps, and urban ruins.



RATFOLK SPY

RATFOLK SPY

Small humanoid (ratfolk), unaligned

Armor Class 13 (leather armor)

Hit Points 27 (6d6 + 6)

Speed 30 ft., climb 20 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
10 (+0)	16 (+3)	12 (+1)	13 (+1)	12 (+1)	11 (+0)

Skills Deception +4, Insight +3, Perception +3, Stealth +7

Senses darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 13

Languages Common, Ratfolk, plus two others

Challenge 1 (200 XP)

False Face. The ratfolk spy has advantage on Charisma (Deception) checks made to pass as a harmless civilian, servant, or minor official.

No Witnesses (If Possible). If the spy deals damage to a surprised creature, it deals an extra 7 (2d6) damage.

ACTIONS

Shortsword. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 6 (1d6 + 3) piercing damage.

Hand Crossbow. *Ranged Weapon Attack:* +5 to hit, range 30/120 ft., one target. *Hit:* 6 (1d6 + 3) piercing damage.

BONUS ACTIONS

Useful Information. As a bonus action, the spy chooses one creature it can see within 60 feet. Until the end of the spy's next turn, the first attack roll made by a ratfolk ally against that creature has advantage.

REACTIONS

Slip Away. When the spy is hit by an attack, it can use its reaction to move up to 15 feet without provoking opportunity attacks.

- Intelligence-gatherer and covert eliminator for ratfolk factions.
- Excels at infiltration, misdirection, and surprise attacks.
- Best used ahead of encounters or embedded among civilian populations.



RATFOLK GRENADIER

RATFOLK GRENADIER

Small humanoid (ratfolk), unaligned

Armor Class 13 (leather armor)

Hit Points 39 (6d8 + 12)

Speed 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
10 (+0)	14 (+2)	14 (+2)	13 (+1)	10 (+0)	8 (–1)

Skills Sleight of Hand +4, Stealth +4

Senses darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 10

Languages Common, Ratfolk

Challenge 2 (450 XP)

Unstable Arsenal. When the ratfolk grenadier uses an explosive, roll a d6. On a 1, the explosive detonates early, centered on the grenadier.

No One's Standing There (Good). The grenadier ignores difficult terrain created by smoke, debris, or rubble.

ACTIONS

Bomb Toss. *Ranged Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, range 30/60 ft. *Hit:* Each creature within 10 feet of that point must make a DC 12 Dexterity saving throw, taking 10 (3d6) fire damage on a failed save, or half as much damage on a successful one.

Smoke Bomb (Recharge 5–6). The grenadier throws a smoke bomb at a point it can see within 30 feet. The area in a 15-foot radius is heavily obscured until the end of the grenadier's next turn.

Dagger. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 4 (1d4 + 2) piercing damage.

BONUS ACTIONS

Smoke and Run. When the grenadier deals damage with an explosive, it can immediately take the Hide or Disengage action as a bonus action.

- Area-denial specialist that thrives on chaos and obscured sightlines.
- High risk, high disruption; Unstable Arsenal keeps tension high.
- Best paired with skirmishers and scouts that exploit smoke cover.



RATFOLK PLAGUE MASTER

RATFOLK PLAGUE MASTER

Small humanoid (ratfolk), unaligned

Armor Class 14 (layered leathers, talismans)

Hit Points 93 (11d8 + 44)

Speed 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
10 (+0)	14 (+2)	18 (+4)	14 (+2)	16 (+3)	9 (−1)

Saving Throws Con +7, Wis +6

Skills Medicine +6, Perception +6, Stealth +5

Damage Resistances poison

Condition Immunities poisoned

Senses darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 16

Languages Common, Ratfolk

Challenge 5 (1,800 XP)

Master of Contagion. Creatures of the plague master's choice that start their turn within 10 feet of it have disadvantage on Constitution saving throws until the start of their next turn.

Rotten Priorities. When another ratfolk within 15 feet of the plague master is reduced to 0 hit points, the plague master gains 10 temporary hit points.

Unpleasant Expertise. The ratfolk plague master has advantage on saving throws against disease, poison, and exhaustion.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. The ratfolk plague master makes two attacks with its plague staff or filthy dart.

Plague Staff. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 10 (1d10 + 4) necrotic damage.

Filthy Dart. *Ranged Weapon Attack:* +5 to hit, range 20/60 ft., one target. *Hit:* 9 (1d10 + 4) poison damage.

Virulent Cloud (Recharge 5–6). The plague master releases a noxious cloud in a 15-foot radius centered on itself. Creatures in the area must make a DC 15 Constitution saving throw, taking 27 (6d8) poison damage on a failed save, or half as much damage on a successful one. The area is lightly obscured until the end of the plague master's next turn.

BONUS ACTIONS

Blight and Flee. When the ratfolk plague master has half its hit points or fewer, it can take the Disengage or Hide action as a bonus action on each of its turns.

- Area-denial controller that weakens Con saves for allied effects.
- Feeds on allied losses to stay standing longer than expected.
- Pairs extremely well with plague adepts, grenadiers, and swarm tactics.



COMPATIBLE CONTENT

Ratfolk can be found lurking in [city sewers](#) or operating openly in a [seedy tavern](#).

LEGAL

This work includes material from the System Reference Document 5.1 © Wizards of the Coast LLC, available under the Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International License.

© 2026 MmpApps Corp. All rights reserved.

Except for material derived from the System Reference Document 5.1, all original content in this work is the exclusive property of MmpApps Corp. and is not licensed under the Creative Commons license. Text was formatted using [The Homebrewery](#).